Question 5 is not needed after answering question 1. Obviously, the distance from point A to B is the same as the distance from point B to A, and we usually call it the distance between points A and B. But as mathematicians we are supposed to note down properties as and when we see them, so it is better to note this too: distance (A,B) = distance (B,A). This is true for all points A and B on the plane, so of course question 5 is same as question 1.

Note

The equation distance(A,B)=distance(B,A) is not always obvious. Suppose that the road from A to B is a one-way street on which you cannot go the other way? Then the distance from B to A might be longer ! But we will avoid all these complications and assume that we can go both ways.

What about the other questions? They are not the same. Since we know that the two houses are on the same street which is running north – south, the y-distance tells us the answer to question 1. Similarly, we know that the library and Shanmugam's house are on the same street running east – west, we can take the x-distance to answer question 2.

Questions 3 and 4 depend on what kind of routes are available. If we assume that the only streets available are parallel to the x and y axes at the points marked 1, 2, 3 etc then we answer these questions by adding the x and y distances. But consider the large field east of Akila's house.

If she can walk across the field, of course she would prefer it. Now there are many ways of going from one place to another, so when we talk of the distance between them, it is not precise. We need some way to fix what we mean. When there are many routes between A and B, we will use distance(A,B) to denote the distance on the shortest route between A and B.

Once we think of distance(A,B) as the "straight line distance" between A and B, there is an elegant way of understanding it for any points A and B on the plane. This is the important reason for using the co-ordinate system at all ! Before that, 2 more questions from our example.

1. With the school as origin, define the coordinates of the two houses, the school and the library.
2. Use the coordinates to give the distance between any one of these and another.

The "straight line distance" is usually called "as the crow flies". This is to mean that we don't worry about any obstacles and routes on the ground, but how we would get from A to B if we could fly. No bird ever flies on straight lines, though.

We can give a systematic answer to this: given any two points $A = (x,y)$ and $B = (x', y')$ on the plane, find distance(A,B). It is easy to derive a formula in terms of the four numbers x, y, x' and y'. This is what we set out to do now.

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